CHAPTER 10 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Compromise of 1877

The backroom bargain that settled a disputed election — and formally ended Reconstruction. 1876–1877.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The backroom bargain that settled a disputed election — and formally ended Reconstruction. 1876–1877.

When is a compromise a wise way to avoid conflict, and when is it a betrayal of the people left out of the deal?

An Election No One Could Win

NOVEMBER 1876

The presidential election of 1876 was a mess. Democrat Samuel Tilden won the popular vote, but the electoral votes of three Southern states — still contested by federal power and fraud on both sides — were disputed. Without them, neither Tilden nor Republican Rutherford B. Hayes had a majority.

For months the nation had no clear president-elect, and there was real fear of renewed violence. A special electoral commission was formed to decide.

An Uneasy Peace

THOMAS NAST, 1877

Nast captured the fragile bargain that resolved the crisis — a truce between North and South, made over the heads of the people it would most affect.

"A Truce — Not a Compromise" — wood engraving by Thomas Nast, Harper's Weekly, 1877, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Bargain in the Shadows

THE DEAL

Behind closed doors, party leaders struck a deal. The Democrats would accept Hayes as president. In return, Hayes would withdraw the last federal troops from the South — the troops that were the final protection for Black citizens and Republican state governments.

The remaining Reconstruction governments collapsed almost immediately. The era of federal protection for the freedpeople was over.

Redemption, 1869–77 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

A Deal Over Their Heads

WHO PAID THE PRICE

For white politicians North and South, the Compromise of 1877 was a success — it avoided a crisis and let the country move on. But it was a success bought at a terrible price, paid by someone else.

The people not at the bargaining table — the four million freedpeople — were abandoned to the mercy of the "Redeemer" governments that now ruled the South. Reconstruction was formally dead, and Jim Crow was about to be born.

FREDERICK DOUGLASS, ON THE NATION'S RETREAT

The question now is … whether … the reconstruction … shall be maintained, or whether … the freedom of the Negro shall be a mockery and a delusion.

Argue the Bargain

YOUR TURN

You'll weigh the arguments for and against the Compromise of 1877 and practice argumentation — deciding whether it was a necessary peace or a shameful betrayal.